

Comfort Zone

With tremendous laptop adoption rates, setting up a wireless home network is the need of the hour—after all, what's the point of having a laptop if you can't use it from the comfort of your bed. With that in mind, we took a look at the best WiFi technology, to help you not only browse the Internet, but also stream music, movies and work.

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We are no aliens to wireless communication. Cell phones with Bluetooth and IR, cordless phones, remote controls, etc are few wireless technologies we use on a daily basis. However, these short distance wireless technologies have limited scope, and today we see yet another development—WiFi.

WiFi is the commercial name for a group of standards designated by the IEEE as 802.11a, 802.11b, 802.11g and now 802.11n. Each of these standards have their own characteristics, mostly defined by the data throughput, frequency at which they operate, and signal coverage area. 802.11a is

the oldest of the lot. Laptops are generally equipped with 802.11g, while 802.11n is a relatively newer version that differs in many ways.

Although the 802.11a standard was the first to be released, it was 802.11b and g, which saw rapid acceptance because of Intel's Centrino platform, which came integrated in all laptops. As of today, most laptops come with an 802.11g module, but newer laptops based on the latest Centrino platform are seeing 802.11n-based parts. With the 802.11n standard being new and currently in the draft stage, that is, the standard is yet to be completely finalised, care must be taken when choosing 802.11n-capable rou-

ters—compatibility issues abound. So whether 802.11n is ready for acceptance is the one big question on everyone's mind, and we will try to answer it in this test.

WiMAX is yet another technology often talked about. Will it replace WiFi, in the longer run? No! WiFi was developed for LAN (local area network) applications, whereas WiMAX is developed for MAN (metropolitan area network). Simply put, WiMAX extends the WiFi experience over a large geographical area, and hence the two will co-exist. This situation is quite similar to using Bluetooth and WiFi—Bluetooth for small range and

